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THE BUILD: COPY GUIDE



Every word you need for a new website.

BY MK PARRISH · \$45

WHAT THIS IS

Building a website is not primarily a design problem. It's a copy problem. Most sites fail at the sentence level — the headline says nothing, the about page talks only about the company, the services page lists features with no outcomes. A beautiful site with weak copy is a beautiful building with no address.

This is the copy guide for The Build — my full-site strategy and production service — written so it stands alone. Every section, every page, every sentence you'll need: frameworks, fill-in templates, worked examples, swipe copy, and the one test that separates copy that converts from copy that just sounds nice.

Work top to bottom. Fill in the brief first; it makes every page downstream easier. Then write each page from its template, and run the whole thing through the test in Section Six before you ship.

“*Nobody reads your website. They scan it for evidence they're in the right place. Write for the scan, earn the read.*”

SECTION ONE: BEFORE YOU WRITE ANYTHING

The Positioning Brief

Five questions. Every word on the site comes from the answers. Write them down before you touch a single page.

1. **Who is this for?** One specific person, not a category.
2. **What's the one thing you do better or differently than anyone else?**
3. **What does the reader most need to believe to hire you?**
4. **What's the single most common objection — and the honest answer to it?**
5. **What do you want them to do right now?**

Worked example (a boutique financial-modeling firm):

For: a non-financial seed-stage founder prepping to raise. Better/different: we build the model AND teach you to defend it in the room. Need to believe: this won't be generic spreadsheet theater. Top objection: "I can find a cheaper template" → answer: a template can't answer an investor's follow-up; we build for the questions, not the cells. Action: book a 20-minute fit call.

The Voice Snapshot

Three adjectives, three banned words, one "sounds like us" sentence. This is what keeps the site from reading like a committee wrote it.

Fill-in: We sound _____, _____, _____. We never say _____, _____, _____. At our best we write lines like: " _____."

SECTION TWO: THE HOMEPAGE

One job: convince the right person they're in the right place, and point them to one next step.

The Hero

- **H1 formula:** *[What you do] for [who]* — with a verb, not a noun. ✓ "We build financial models for early-stage founders." ✗ "Financial Strategy Solutions." (A noun-pile says nothing; a verb makes a promise.)
- **Subhead formula:** the specific outcome your best clients get, in one sentence. *"Walk into your raise able to defend every number — not just present it."*
- **CTA:** use a verb that names the next step. **"Book a fit call"** / **"See the work"** / **"Get the model."** Never "Learn More" — it commits the reader to nothing and converts nothing.

The Social Proof Strip

Three kinds of proof, in order of power: **specific outcomes** ("closed a \$3M seed six weeks after we built the model"), **named quotes** (with company + title), **recognizable logos.** One line of real outcome beats five vague testimonials.

The Services Preview — the three-card rule

No more than three cards on the homepage. Each card: a one-line title, a one-line **outcome**, one CTA.

Example card — "The Raise Model · An investor-ready model you can defend in the room · See how it works →"

The About Preview

One paragraph, written about what you **believe** — not who you are. It's a conviction statement, not a bio.

Example: "We think most founders lose the room not on the idea but on the math they can't defend. So we build the math with you, until the answer to every follow-up is already in your head."

The Final CTA

Restate the offer simply, then add the friction-reducer that answers the last hesitation before the click.

Example: "Book a 20-minute fit call. If we're not the right fit, we'll tell you on the call and point you somewhere better."

SECTION THREE: THE SERVICES PAGES

A services page fails one of two ways: features with no outcomes, or outcomes so vague it forgets to say what you actually get. Use this frame per service:

- **Header:** service name + one-line outcome.
- **The problem:** 3–4 sentences describing *their* situation, in their words, not your pitch.
- **The solution:** what you do and what it produces, concretely. *"You get X, Y, and Z. Within [timeframe] you'll have [deliverable]."*
- **The process (optional):** 3–5 steps. Makes the abstract feel real and de-risks the buy.
- **The proof:** one case or quote specific to *this* service.
- **The CTA:** price anchor ("from \$X") + booking link.

Worked mini-example — "The Raise Model":

Problem: "You're weeks from a raise with a spreadsheet you didn't build and can't fully defend. The model looks fine until an investor asks why churn flattens in month 14." Solution: "We rebuild your model with you — assumptions you can explain, scenarios you can run live, and a one-page summary that answers the five questions investors always ask. In two weeks you'll have a model and the fluency to defend it." Proof: [client quote]. CTA: "From \$6,000 · Book a fit call →"

The pack includes adaptable templates for six page types: **retainer, project, digital product, course, coaching, done-for-you.**

SECTION FOUR: THE ABOUT PAGE

The most miswritten page on the internet. Most About pages are about the company; the best are about the reader, told through how you came to care. Six parts:

1. **The empathy opener** — start with *them*. Name the situation they're in.
2. **The bridge** — how you came to understand that situation. The true version.
3. **The conviction** — what you believe that shapes the work. A point of view, not a values list.
4. **The credentials** — brief, specific, ordered by relevance, not prestige.
5. **The human detail** — one non-professional thing. People buy from people.
6. **The CTA** — one next step.

Annotated opener example: *"Most founders don't lose the raise on the idea. They lose it on a number they can't defend at 4pm in a cold conference room. [empathy] I learned that the hard way, sitting in those rooms as the analyst who watched great companies fumble the math. [bridge] So I stopped building models for founders and started building them with founders — because the model isn't the deliverable; the confidence is. [conviction]"*

SECTION FIVE: THE CONTACT & BOOKING PAGES

The last page before they decide — and the one most likely to abandon them at the worst moment.

- **The micro-headline:** one line that justifies the friction of the form. *"Tell us where you are in your raise — we'll reply within one business day."*
- **The expectation-setter:** say exactly what happens next, with a timeline. *"You'll get a real reply from MK (not a bot) within 24 hours, with two times to talk."*
- **Form fields:** include only what you'll act on. Every extra field lowers completion. Name, email, one open question usually beats a ten-field interrogation.
- **The booking page:** warm the conversation above the embed. *"This is a 20-minute fit call. Come with one question about your raise; leave knowing whether we can help."*

SECTION SIX: THE ONE TEST

Run every sentence on the site through one question:

“

Does this sentence help the right person take the right action — or does it just make us feel good?

✗ Feels good: "We are a leading provider of integrated strategic financial solutions."

✓ Helps them: "We build the investor model you can actually defend in the room."

It's not an elegant test. It's just useful. Run all of it through before you publish — the homepage hero first, the About second, because those are where the feel-good sentences hide.

THE TEMPLATES (AND HOW TO USE THEM)

Each is a Google Doc you copy to your Drive — and every frame above is ready to rebuild anywhere: the **Positioning Brief**, the **Voice Snapshot**, the **Homepage template** (hero → proof → services → about → final CTA), the **Services Page template** (six types), the **About Page template** (annotated), the **Contact/Booking template**, and the **Copy Review Checklist** (the one test + 12 line-level checks). Fill them with your real positioning. The structure is the gift; the words have to be yours.

KEEP GOING

This is the copy companion to **The Build** — my full-site strategy and production service. If you'd rather hand the whole site to a team that does this daily, that's the service.

If the *positioning* underneath the copy still feels blurry, run the free **Positioning Checklist** first — it diagnoses the leaks before you write. And if your brand *voice* keeps going generic, **The Brand Voice Playbook** is the system that fixes it. Both at mkparrish.com.

A website doesn't need more words. It needs the right ones, in the right order, pointed at one action. Now you have them.

— MK Parrish

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